COMMUNAL RIOTS DELETIONS

CLASS 12: POLITICAL SCIENCE



■ In the last chapter of ***Politics in India Since Independence,*** two pages on the 2002 Gujarat riots have been deleted. The first page carried a detailed report of the riots and mentioned the NHRC's criticism of the Gujarat government for failing to control the violence. A deleted passage states: "Instances, like in Gujarat, alert us to the dangers involved in using religious sentiments for political purposes. This poses a threat to democratic politics." The second page carried a collage of three newspaper reports on the riots along with an excerpt of the NHRC's observation from its annual report. It also had then PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee's "raj dharma" remark at a press conference in Ahmedabad in March 2002 with Narendra Modi, the then Gujarat chief minister, sitting by his side.

CLASS 12: SOCIOLOGY

■ References to the 1984 anti-Sikh riots as well as the Gujarat riots have also been removed from the textbook, ***Indian Society***. The deleted paragraph under the section, 'Communalism, Secularism and the Nation-State' in Chapter 6 read: "A commonly cited justification is to avenge the deaths or dishonour suffered by their co-religionists elsewhere or even in the distant past. No region has been wholly exempt from communal violence of one kind or another. Every religious community has faced this violence in greater or lesser degree, although the proportionate impact is far more traumatic for minority communities. To the extent that governments can be held responsible for communal riots, no government or ruling party can claim to be blameless in this regard. In fact, the two most traumatic contemporary instances of communal violence occurred under each of the major political parties. The anti-Sikh riots of Delhi in 1984 took place under a Congress regime. The unprecedented scale and spread of anti-Muslim violence in Gujarat in 2002 took place under the BJP government."

It's not just the Class 12 textbooks, the ones for lower classes have been revised too. For instance, the Class 10 textbook, *Democratic Politics-II*, has three chapters—'Democracy and Diversity', 'Challenges to Democracy' and 'Popular Struggles and Movements'—excised. The first chapter introduced students to the concept of social divisions and inequalities along race and caste lines across the world. The second talked about reforming democratic politics. The third looked at indirect ways of influencing politics via pressure groups and movements, NBA among them. Former NCERT director Krishna Kumar says these cuts have left some of the remaining topics "incomprehensible." For instance, students will now learn about the Constitution without any understanding of India's federal structure, he says. The chapter 'India after Independence', which talks about the framing of the Constitution and the making of linguistic states, has been removed from the Class 8 history textbook, *Our Pasts III*.

Several experts on history as well as political opponents assert that the BJP's textbook content rationalisation exercise is designed exclusively to erase Muslim contributions to Indian society while simultaneously glorifying Hindus. If Aditya Mukherjee, who taught contemporary history at Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) in Delhi, says that the rationalisation exercise is purely a political move and has got nothing to do with Covid-19 (see *The Politics Behind History*), medieval historian Harbans Mukhia, also a former professor of JNU, believes that this is part of the BJP's strat-